

SEO SOP: Find the Traffic You're Leaving on the Table with the Expected-CTR Model

A repeatable SEO SOP · seoarcade.com · Distilled from David Wilson (Zozimus) on Unscripted SEO

Objective

Turn Google Search Console position data into a prioritized list of recoverable traffic. Map each page's average position to a published position→CTR curve to get its **expected** CTR, compare to the **actual** CTR it earns, and treat the gap as recoverable clicks (and, for commercial pages, revenue). The result is a short list of below-curve pages where a meta/title/on-page fix wins back clicks the page already qualifies for — without chasing new rankings.

Key Steps

1. **Export per-page GSC data (full set, not 1,000 rows).** Pull 3–12 months of *Pages* performance with clicks, impressions, and average position. A free Google Sheets add-on pulls up to 25,000 rows — "a huge difference" over the UI export.
2. **Pick a published position→CTR curve.** Use one industry CTR-by-position benchmark consistently (e.g. ~9% at position four) so every page is judged against the same yardstick.
3. **Calculate expected CTR per page.** Match average position to the curve, then multiply expected CTR by impressions to get the clicks the page *should* earn.
4. **Calculate actual CTR and find the gap.** Actual CTR = clicks ÷ impressions. A page at position two earning 4% when the curve says 9% runs at ~half its traffic — that delta is the gap.
5. **Rank by recoverable clicks (and revenue).** Multiply the CTR gap by impressions, sort largest-first. For commercial pages, extend by conversion rate and AOV — the miss can be "hundreds of thousands per month."
6. **Fix the below-curve pages on-page.** Rewrite the title tag and meta description and refresh the on-page text Google pulls into the snippet, so the listing earns the click its position qualifies it for. This "unblocks the dammed creek."
7. **Re-measure after recrawl, then repeat.** Recompute actual vs. expected CTR on the same pages to confirm the gap closed; roll the model forward monthly on the next batch.

Cautionary Notes

- A generic CTR curve is an estimate — branded queries and SERP features skew it. Prioritize with it; sanity-check outliers.
- Low-impression pages give noisy gaps — set an impression floor.
- GSC hides some data ("dark clicks"); page totals are directional, not exact.
- Average position blends every query a page ranks for.

Tips for Efficiency

- Let AI crunch it — build the math as a repeatable Claude/ChatGPT prompt; hours, not weeks.
- Start with money pages — biggest recoverable revenue, fastest buy-in.
- Lead with the number: "4% and should be 9% — you could double this traffic."
- Keep a before/after CTR log to bank the wins.

Source

David Wilson, Zozimus — framed this as an "expected click traffic" process on the Unscripted SEO podcast (host Jeremy Rivera). His throughline: optimize for business results, not rankings.

Full interview: unscriptedseo.com/search-everywhere-optimization-driving-business-results-not-just-rankings/ · More SOPs: seoarcade.com/tag/seo-standard-operating-procedures/ · © SEO Arcade